of course, Britain, while the latter would conclude its own treaty with Afghanistan.[6] How these treaties all affected one another is a question, however, which has yet to be fully explored. So, while others may have asked what the Anglo-Soviet Trade Agreement meant for Anglo-Russian relations, the following pages will focus instead on how affairs with Russia affected Britain's policies towards Persia and Afghanistan in 1921. Furthermore, this chapter will try to understand to what extent the British government underwent an actual change in attitude regarding not only its policy towards Soviet Russia, but, more specifically, towards Persia and Afghanistan; it will try to see how far any such change was real or simply superficial. Finally, given the setbacks he had experienced, had the Great Game mentality of Curzon actually died a death by 1921 or was it struggling on?

Shadow for Substance

In a speech to the House of Lords in July 1921, Curzon described the situation in Persia as one which left him with 'a feeling of disappointment, almost of despair'. All his previous efforts in Persia he believed to have been in vain, and he was 'unaware of any encouragement at the present moment to persevere in this task'.[7] This was an apt summary of Curzon's feelings in 1921, as well as a telling indication of the change that the foreign secretary had undergone in relation to Persia in the last year or so. As noted, Persia was Curzon's apparent area of expertise, and the policies pursued by the British government towards this country in the post-war period were created and driven almost entirely by him. It is therefore hardly surprising that the foreign secretary should feel such despondency when surveying what the last two years of his handiwork had done to Britain's position in Persia. Rather than attaining a position of unrivalled hegemony over a secure and stable buffer state, Britain's standing in that country – and its reputation in Asia at large – appeared to have sunk to an all time low.

And yet, rather than realising the error of his ways, and admitting that he may have failed to appreciate the nature of the post-war world, Curzon was to react as if he had been personally insulted by the Persians. Even at this